A Visitor's Guide to the Reading Room

Before you come

The firm's books were kept in the Italian manner, but the clerks of the period were not always consistent in their treatment of the discount. A ship's master was at once a navigator, a trader and a disciplinarian, and the owners trusted him with a good deal more than the sailing of the vessel. The firm's books were kept in the Italian manner, but the clerks of the period were not always consistent in their treatment of the discount.

The wages of seamen were fixed by the month, and a man discharged abroad had a claim to his pay up to the day of his discharge. A merchant of Bristol who lost a ship in the autumn might find that his factors in Waterford had already drawn upon him for the whole of the spring crop. The reader who comes to these papers expecting the great questions of the age will find instead a very close attention to casks, hoops and freight. The wages of seamen were fixed by the month, and a man discharged abroad had a claim to his pay up to the day of his discharge.

The firm's books were kept in the Italian manner, but the clerks of the period were not always consistent in their treatment of the discount. The cooper's trade was as important as the shipwright's, for a cask that leaked was a cargo lost, and the cost fell on the owner. The wages of seamen were fixed by the month, and a man discharged abroad had a claim to his pay up to the day of his discharge. Credit was extended for months at a time, and a house that called in its debts too sharply would soon find itself without correspondents. The volume of trade can be estimated from the duties paid, though the figures need to be read with care, since cargoes were often entered at a round number.

The sugar trade of the eighteenth century rested upon credit, and credit rested upon the character of the man who gave it. The sugar trade of the eighteenth century rested upon credit, and credit rested upon the character of the man who gave it. The correspondence shows a house that was careful rather than bold, and which seldom put more than a third of its capital into any one voyage. The wages of seamen were fixed by the month, and a man discharged abroad had a claim to his pay up to the day of his discharge.

Insurance was dear, and the underwriters of the Exchange coffee house were slow to pay a claim that touched upon the capture of a vessel. A merchant of Bristol who lost a ship in the autumn might find that his factors in Cork had already drawn upon him for the whole of the spring crop. The wages of seamen were fixed by the month, and a man discharged abroad had a claim to his pay up to the day of his discharge.

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In the reading room

- Pencils only, and no bags at the tables.
- Handle volumes on the foam supports provided.
- Ask a member of staff before you open any bound volume wider than a right angle.

The partners wrote to each other even when they lived a mile apart, partly from habit and partly because a letter was a record that could be shown to a court. Freight rates moved with the season and with the news from Europe, and a rumour of war could double the cost of a voyage within a week. Some of the most revealing documents in the collection are the least formal: a note about a wet cargo, or a list of things to be bought for a ship.

The reader who comes to these papers expecting the great questions of the age will find instead a very close attention to casks, hoops and freight. What survives is uneven: whole years are missing, and the letters that remain were kept, as often as not, because they recorded a debt. It is the small entries, the cost of a boat or the loan of a lantern, that tell us most about the daily life of the quay.

Copying and photography

Where the surviving accounts can be checked against the port books, they are in general remarkably accurate, if rarely complete. Seen from the counting house, the abolition debates of the period were at first a distant noise, and only later a matter of direct concern. No account of the trade can ignore the part played by the factors, who stood between the planter and the merchant and took a commission from both. The volume of trade can be estimated from the duties paid, though the figures need to be read with care, since cargoes were often entered at a round number.

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